

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Methodology & Scope:

Ratings are based on search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia, Amazon, and 20+ other sites.

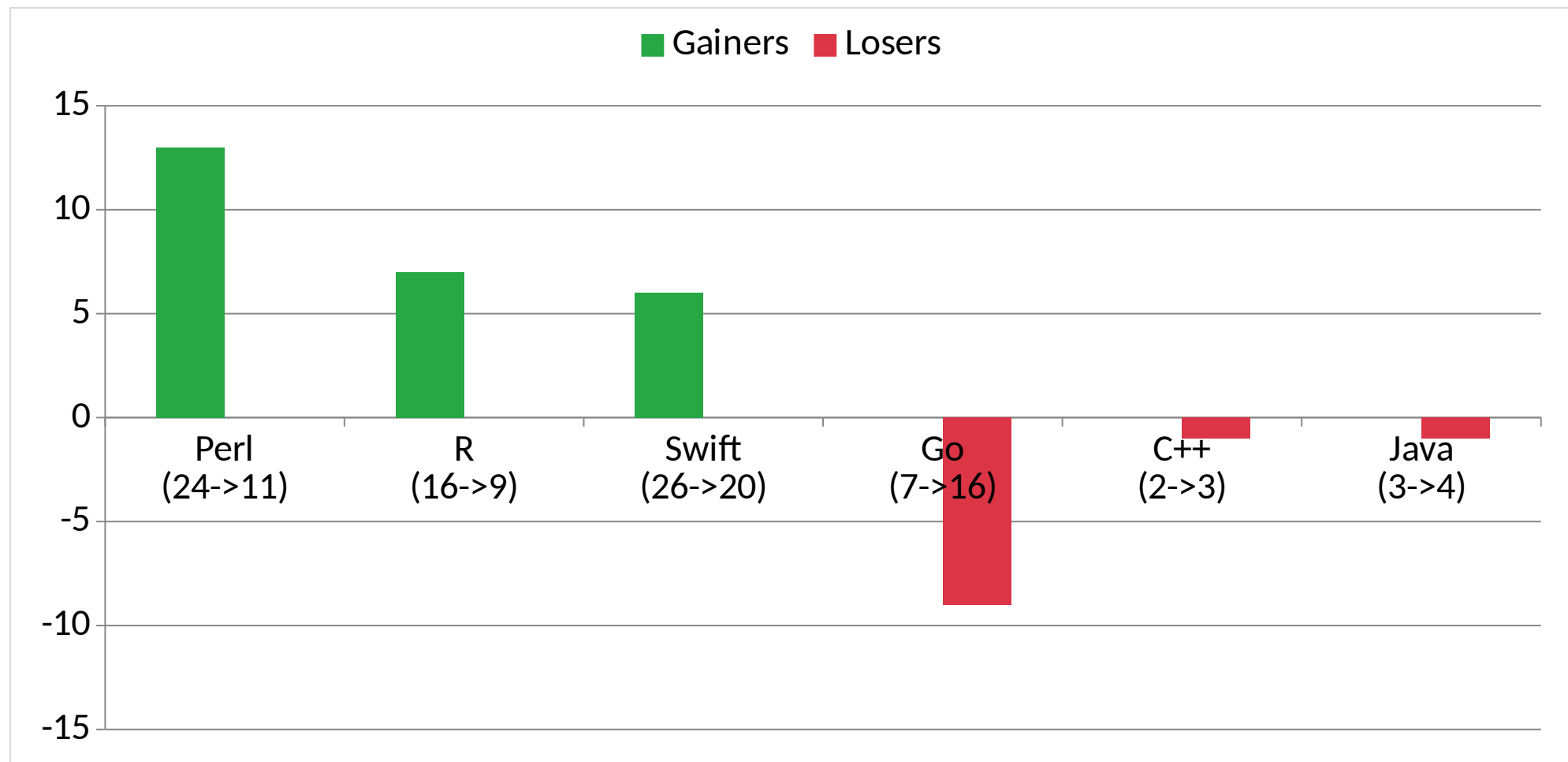
Goal: Provide technology decision-makers with a data-backed view of language momentum to align hiring, training, and tooling investments

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

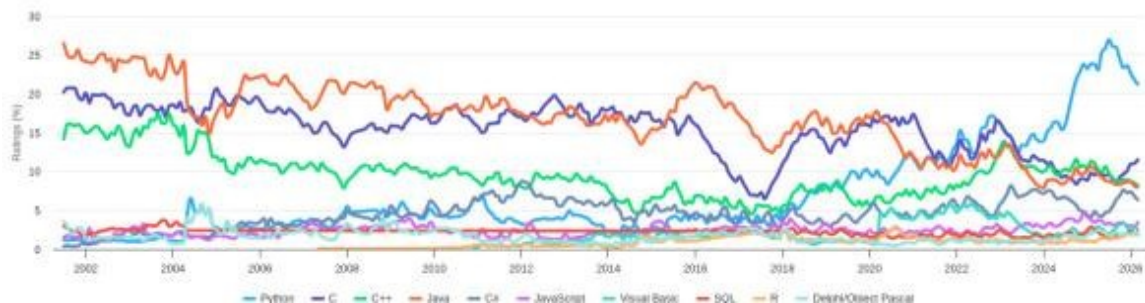
Rank (Mar '26)	Rank (Mar '25)	Programming Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

Python holds 21.25%, dominating the index.
C gains +2.02%, surging to 2nd place.

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 -- The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026



From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time



Programming Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	-	-
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	-	-
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-	-	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	-	-
Visual Basic	7	6	11	-	-	-	-	-	-
Delphi/Object Pascal	8	185	12	12	9	-	-	-	-
SQL	9	10	-	-	-	-	-	-	-
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2
(Visual) Basic	-	-	-	6	6	4	3	3	4

- Python: Rose from unranked (1986) to dominant #1 (2026)
- Java: Peaked around 2016 and steadily declined
- C: Remained in the top 2 across all nine measurement points over four decades

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times

-- More Than Any Other Language

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

Python leads with 6 total wins: 2007, 2010, 2018, 2020, 2021, and 2024.

C# has won twice recently (2023, 2025), fueled by the .NET ecosystem.

Go won in 2016, preceding its current decline in 2026.

Note: The 2017 winner is not available in the source data.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

- **Concentration Risk:** Python, C, C++, and Java account for 48.97% of total ratings. Betting heavily on niche languages carries isolation risks.
- **Python's Dual Narrative:** While it holds a massive 21.25% share, it also saw the largest YoY drop (-2.59%), suggesting market saturation.
- **C's Resurgence:** C gained +2.02%, jumping to 2nd place—a powerful reminder that core systems languages remain vital.
- **Legacy Languages Endure:** Perl (+13 spots), Fortran, and R are seeing revivals, serving entrenched data and scientific communities.
- **Go's Sharp Fall:** Dropping 9 spots to #16, Go is facing intense pressure, potentially from Rust in the systems space.